CHAINS — CALHOUN CONFRONTATION THREAD

Trigger Condition: CALHOUN_REL: HOSTILE or CALHOUN_INCIDENTS 3+ by Night 9 **Night:** Night 9 **Location:** Main road → Root cellar, old Pruitt barn **Key Flags:** ROOT_CELLAR_KNOWN, RICKY_ALIVE, MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED, HATTIE_DEAD

JACOB MARSH — TIMELINE CORRECTION

> *Jacob Marsh disappeared **five years ago.** Not two. Calhoun has been managing this secret for five years. Eleanor has been sitting in that house for five years. The churchyard has had an empty box in it for five years. This is not a fresh wound — it is a settled, structural lie that Wroughtwood built itself around.*

CALHOUN'S ASSESSMENT — How He Got Here

Calhoun has been watching Marcus since Day 1. Every incident, every report from Ricky, every conversation Pruitt relayed without meaning to — Calhoun has been building a file in his head.

He has done this before. His father did it before him. The method is simple and has worked twice:

Identify the infected. Isolate them. Chain them in the cellar. Wait.

The host dies within two to three weeks of full containment — the wolf starves without being able to feed, the human body can't sustain the infection without release, and eventually one of them gives out. Calhoun has never lost sleep over this. He thinks of it as pest control. The fact that there's a person involved is, to him, a complication rather than a moral consideration.

Marcus has been more difficult than the previous cases. He's been moving through town, building relationships, getting close to things Calhoun doesn't want examined. The Eleanor situation — he knows Marcus visited her. He doesn't know how much she said. That uncertainty accelerated his timeline.

Night 9. Before the next full moon cycle peaks. Before Marcus gets any deeper into the north woods.

BUILDING TO CHAINS — Calhoun's Escalation Track

> *CHAINS only triggers if the relationship has deteriorated. Each incident adds to CALHOUN_INCIDENTS counter.*

Event	CALHOUN_INCIDENTS
Calhoun C1 — Marcus provokes at first meeting	+1
Calhoun C2 — Marcus stops and holds eye contact	+1
Calhoun C3 — Hattie defends Marcus publicly	+1
Calhoun C3 — Marcus uses wolf presence	+2
CALHOUN_KNOWS_WOODS discovered by Marcus	+1 — Calhoun senses Marcus is getting close
MARSH_TRUSTS_MARCUS set	+2 — Eleanor talked. Calhoun knows.
PRUITT_JOURNAL_FOUND	+2 — Someone has been in Pruitt's desk
SHACK_FOUND	+3 — Marcus found the north woods. Calhoun's timeline collapses.
Blackout event visible in town	+2

CALHOUN_INCIDENTS **4 or below:** Calhoun watches. Waits. CHAINS does not trigger.
CALHOUN_INCIDENTS **5+:** Calhoun begins preparing. CHAINS triggers Night 9.

COMPOSURE PREVENTION — Avoiding CHAINS

> *If Marcus has maintained COMPOSURE throughout his dealings with Calhoun, a prevention path is available.*

Condition: COMPOSURE score 15+ AND CALHOUN_INCIDENTS below 5

Calhoun is a practical man. A Marcus who has kept his head, done his work, stayed out of Calhoun's business publicly — that Marcus gives Calhoun less to act on. Not because Calhoun becomes decent. Because he can't justify the action to himself or anyone else without incident evidence.

The Prevention Scene — Day 8, Afternoon:

Calhoun finds Marcus on the main road. No audience this time — deliberate.

He falls into step beside Marcus without preamble.

"You've been here over a week," he says. Conversational. *"Longer than most strangers last."*

He walks.

"I'm going to say something to you and I want you to hear it plainly." He stops. Turns to face Marcus. His eyes are flat and specific. *"I know what you are. I know what's happening to you. And I know what happens next if you stay in these woods through another full moon."*

A beat.

"Leave Wroughtwood. Tonight if you can manage it. Don't come back."

He is not threatening. He is, in his own way, giving Marcus a chance he didn't give Jacob Marsh.

[PLAYER CHOICE]

A — "I'm not leaving until I find what I came for." Calhoun looks at him for a long time. *"Then God help you,"* he says. And means it in the flattest possible way. CHAINS_PREVENTION_FAILED — Night 9 proceeds.

B — "What do you know about it?" *"Enough."* He doesn't elaborate. *"My family has been cleaning up after this land for three generations. I'm tired of it."* This opens a single additional exchange — Marcus can push and Calhoun will confirm the method. The root cellar. The chains. That he did it before. *"The last one was a boy from this town,"* he says. *"Five years ago."* He watches Marcus's face when he says it. CALHOUN_ADMITTED_JACOB set — he confirmed it. First time he's said it to anyone. If Marcus says *"Jacob Marsh"* — Calhoun goes very still. *"Eleanor talked."* Not anger. Something heavier. *"Then you know what I did and why I did it."* CHAINS_PREVENTION_PARTIAL — Night 9 still possible but CALHOUN_INCIDENTS threshold raises to 7.

C — "I know about the cellar." The flat eyes sharpen for one second. Then settle. *"Then we understand each other,"* he says. He walks away. CHAINS_ON_ALERT — Calhoun accelerates. Night 8 instead of Night 9 if CALHOUN_INCIDENTS 5+.

NIGHT 9 — THE AMBUSH

> *Triggers if CALHOUN_INCIDENTS 5+ and prevention failed or not available.*

Marcus goes out at night. He has reasons — the hunger, the investigation, the moon phase pulling at him. He has done it before. The town is quiet. The road is empty.

It isn't empty.

They come from two directions. Calhoun from the front, stepping out of the shadow of the feed store with a lantern held low. Ricky from behind — and Ricky has a gun. A short-barreled revolver that he is holding with both hands and the particular rigidity of someone who is more afraid than the person he's pointing it at.

Two other men flank from the alleys. Marcus didn't see them. The wolf in him clocked them half a second too late.

Calhoun looks at Marcus the way a man looks at a problem he's finally gotten around to solving.

"I gave you the chance to walk away," he says. *"You didn't take it."*

THE CELLAR — CHAINED

They walk Marcus to the old Pruitt barn at the south edge of town. The root cellar entrance is set into the barn floor — heavy wood doors, iron hinges, a bolt that has been recently oiled. They knew where they were going. They prepared.

Inside: cold earth walls, a single lantern left burning low, and chains. Heavy iron, bolted into the wall at one end. Old but maintained. Calhoun's father installed them. Calhoun has kept them ready for five years.

They chain Marcus's wrists to the wall. Enough slack to sit or stand. Not enough to reach the door.

Calhoun crouches in front of Marcus before he leaves. The lantern between them.

"This isn't personal," he says. *"You came to the wrong town at the wrong time. That's not your fault."*

He stands.

"It won't take long. A few weeks at most."

He goes. Ricky pulls the cellar door shut. The bolt slides home.

CHAINS_ACTIVE **set Stat Effect:** RAGE +20, HUNGER +15 — confinement feeds both **Night cycle begins in the cellar.**

THE CELLAR — DAYS CHAINED

> *Marcus is imprisoned. Time still passes. Each day chained has events.*

DAY 1 CHAINED — The Silence

The cellar is dark when the lantern burns out. Marcus can hear the barn above him — wind through the boards, mice, the occasional footstep when Ricky checks the bolt.

The hunger is loud.

RAGE climbs +15 per night chained. HUNGER climbs +20 per night chained. HUMANITY drifts -5 per day without human contact.

The wolf wants out. The chains are iron — they hold. For now.

DAY 2 CHAINED — PATH SPLIT

> *This is where the two resolution paths diverge.*

RESOLUTION PATH 1 — MARIE COMES

Condition: MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED OR MARIE_FORMALLY_MET AND HATTIE_DEAD is NOT set AND RICKY_ALIVE is set

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HOW MARIE KNOWS

Marie knew before it happened. She reads this land the way other people read weather — by what the air does, what the animals do, what the water in the swamp does the night before something goes wrong. She felt the chains close around Marcus from half a mile away.

She did not come the first night. She waited to see if Marcus could get free himself. He couldn't.

She comes on the second night.

MARIE'S ARRIVAL — Night 2

The barn is quiet. Ricky is sitting on a crate above the cellar doors, the revolver on his knee, half asleep.

He doesn't hear her coming. No one ever does.

She stands at the barn entrance for a moment. She looks at Ricky with the particular attention she gives things she has already decided about. Then she walks toward him and he wakes up and raises the gun and she doesn't stop walking.

"Put that down, cher," she says softly.

She doesn't touch him. She doesn't need to.

Something happens to Ricky's face. It goes slack in a specific way — not unconscious, not absent. Like the part of him that makes decisions has stepped aside for something else to use the controls. His eyes stay open. He stays upright.

Marie crouches in front of him at eye level.

"You're going to open those doors," she says. *"And then you're going to have a conversation with your uncle."*

THE CELLAR DOORS OPEN

Light from Marie's lantern falls into the cellar. Marcus looks up.

She looks down at him. At the chains. At the state of him after two nights.

"Mmm," she says. The sound of a woman whose assessment has been confirmed.

She comes down the cellar steps and examines the chains. She doesn't have a key. She doesn't need one. She takes the lock in both hands and is still for a moment and then the lock opens. Simply. Like it decided to.

She doesn't comment on this.

"Can you stand?"

RICKY AND CALHOUN — THE RECKONING

Marie leads Marcus out of the cellar. Ricky is standing in the barn doorway. Still slack-faced. Still holding the gun. But now Calhoun is there — he came when Ricky didn't check in. He is standing ten feet from his nephew with a lantern and an expression moving rapidly between confusion and something approaching fear.

"Ricky," Calhoun says carefully. *"Put the gun down."*

Ricky doesn't put the gun down.

"Ricky."

Marie is standing to the side. She is not looking at Ricky. She is looking at Calhoun with an expression of complete calm.

"He can't hear you right now," she says pleasantly. *"He's busy."*

Calhoun looks at her. Really looks at her — maybe for the first time. He has spent years not looking at her, the way Wroughtwood has spent years not looking at her.

"What are you doing," he says. Quiet. Afraid.

"Correcting something," she says.

THE OUTCOME — Ricky Turns the Gun

Ricky raises the revolver. Points it at his uncle.

Calhoun goes completely still.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Marcus intervenes or lets it play out]

A — Marcus stops it *"That's enough."* He steps forward. Puts himself between the gun and Calhoun. He doesn't know entirely why — maybe because he is still more human than not. Maybe because a dead Calhoun is a complication he can't afford right now. Maybe just because he is Marcus Grave and this is not who he is. Marie watches him. Something in her expression shifts — the closest she gets to impressed. Ricky blinks. The slack leaves his face. He looks at the gun in his hand like he doesn't know how it got there. He drops it. Sits down on the barn floor and puts his face in his hands. Calhoun looks at Marcus. A very long silence. *"Why,"* Calhoun says. *"Because I'm not you,"* Marcus says. CALHOUN_OWES_MARCUS set — the most unexpected flag in the game. Calhoun will not become an ally. But he will get out of Marcus's way for the rest of the story. HUMANITY +15

B — Let it play out The gun goes off. Calhoun goes down — shoulder, not fatal. He hits the barn wall and slides and sits there with his hand pressed to the wound looking at his nephew with an expression Marcus will not forget. Ricky comes back to himself a second later. He looks at what he's done. He starts to make a sound. Marie is already walking back toward the swamp path. *"Come, Marcus,"* she says. CALHOUN_SHOT set — Calhoun survives but is diminished. Ricky is destroyed by what he did. The CHAINS threat is over but the aftermath is loud. HUMANITY -5 — Marcus let it happen. That's true even if he didn't pull the trigger.

RESOLUTION PATH 3 — NO ONE COMES

Condition: MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED NOT set AND HATTIE_DEAD set AND PACK_LOCATION_FOUND NOT set OR MARSH_JACOB_IN_PACK not known

Neither Marie nor Jacob has reason or ability to reach Marcus in time. Hattie is dead or estranged. The relationships Marcus didn't build, the trust he didn't earn, the threads he didn't follow — they all land here in the dark of a root cellar in Wroughtwood.

Calhoun's method works exactly as it always has.

THE CELLAR — DAYS PASSING

The hunger becomes unbearable by Day 2. HUNGER hits 100. RAGE follows.

The wolf tries to get out. The chains are iron. They hold — Calhoun's father built them for exactly this, tested them for exactly this, and they have worked twice before.

By Day 3 Marcus's HEALTH begins dropping. The infection sustains him longer than a normal person would last — the wolf burning through reserves, fighting the confinement, refusing to accept the math of the situation. But the math is patient. Calhoun has always known the math.

Ricky checks the bolt every morning. He doesn't open the doors. He just checks the bolt and walks away.

THE END — Narration

You think about the road. The headlights. The shape in the dark.

You think about Curtis saying don't stop, man — keep driving.

You think about the watch, if you found it. The engraving you couldn't read in the dark.

The wolf goes quiet on the fourth day. Not surrender — exhaustion. Even it has limits.

You think about your name.

Marcus Grave. Twenty-five years old.

You were passing through.

Fade to black.

ENDING: CHAINS *Calhoun's method works. It always has. Nobody comes.*

MARCUS_DEAD set — game over Stat condition: HEALTH → 0 over Days 3–5 chained, accelerated by full HUNGER and RAGE

RESOLUTION PATH 2 — JACOB COMES

Condition: PACK_LOCATION_FOUND AND COMPOSURE maintained throughout Calhoun encounters AND MARSH_JACOB_IN_PACK known

> *This path is available whether or not Marie comes. It can combine with Path 1 or stand alone if Marie conditions aren't met.*

WHAT TRIGGERS JACOB

Jacob Marsh has been in the north woods for five years. He is not the man his mother remembers. But something of the man remains — fragments, instincts, pieces of a person preserved in the wolf like objects preserved in amber.

He knows this land. He has watched Wroughtwood from the tree line for five years. He has seen the barn. He knows what the root cellar is used for. He knows who put him in those woods.

When Marcus went into the north woods — when he found Takoda, followed the trails, got close to the pack's territory — Jacob noticed. The pack noticed. But Jacob noticed *specifically* — this person is being hunted by Calhoun the same way Jacob was hunted. The same chains. The same cellar.

Something that was almost extinguished in Jacob Marsh decides to do something about it.

JACOB'S ARRIVAL — Night 2 or 3

The barn doors don't open from the outside. They come apart.

The bolt shears. The wood around the hinges splinters. The doors fold back like they were nothing.

What stands at the top of the cellar steps is large and wrong in the specific way Marcus has been learning to recognize — the proportions shifted, the stillness not quite animal not quite human. It breathes. It looks down into the dark.

Then it comes down the steps.

Marcus should be afraid. He isn't entirely. The wolf in him reads what this is and goes quiet in the way it goes quiet around things that outrank it.

The chains come off the wall. Not unlocked — *pulled*. The bolts his father sank into that earth five years ago come free like they were suggestions.

Jacob Marsh stands in front of Marcus and breathes.

Then he turns and goes back up the steps. Stops at the top.

Waiting.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Follow or Stay]

A — Follow him Jacob leads Marcus out of the barn and stops in the yard. Calhoun is there — he came running when he heard the doors. He sees what is standing in his barn doorway.

Five years of suppression lands on Aldous Calhoun's face all at once. He recognizes Jacob the way you recognize something you've tried to forget — against your will, completely, all at once.

"Jacob," he says. The word comes out wrong. Too small.

Jacob looks at the man who chained his mother into a lie and waited for him to die.

[PLAYER CHOICE — intervene or stand back] The game does not tell the player what Jacob does if Marcus stands back. The screen cuts to Marcus outside the barn in the early morning, alone. The barn door is open. Calhoun is inside. The player can look or not look. CALHOUN_JACOB_VERDICT set — outcome ambiguous, never confirmed.

B — Stay in the cellar Jacob waits. Marcus doesn't come up. After a moment Jacob goes. The doors hang open. Marcus gets himself out. JACOB_HELPED_MARCUS set — Jacob freed him. Marcus didn't follow. Jacob went and did whatever he went to do alone. CALHOUN_JACOB_VERDICT set — same ambiguous outcome.

RICKY — VARIABLE STATUS NOTE

> *Ricky Calhoun's presence in CHAINS depends on prior events.*

Status	Condition	Effect on CHAINS
RICKY_ALIVE	No prior fatal encounter	Present at ambush, present for Marie's reckoning
RICKY_DEAD_DARNELL	Darnell killed Ricky during hostage situation	Calhoun uses hired man instead. Marie's path still available but the gun scene plays differently — stranger, not family. Less devastating for Calhoun.
RICKY_FLED	Strength path on teens caused Ricky to leave town	Calhoun acts alone with hired men. Marie's path: the hired man is easier to influence than blood, but Calhoun has no witness he loves.

AFTERMATH — CHAINS RESOLVED

However CHAINS resolves — Marie's intervention, Jacob's return, Marcus forcing his own way out if neither path is available — the morning after is the same kind of morning.

Marcus is free. The cellar is behind him. The town knows something happened at the Pruitt barn — sounds in the night, the doors, Calhoun's condition. Pruitt will come asking questions.

What Marcus says to Pruitt — what he can prove, what flags he carries into that conversation — determines whether Calhoun faces any accounting or whether Wroughtwood simply absorbs it the way it has absorbed everything else.

IF CALHOUN_ADMITTED_JACOB set AND PRUITT_REL CORDIAL: Pruitt listens. He sits at his desk for a long time after. He looks at the map on his wall. *"Five years,"* he says quietly. *"Five years,"* Marcus confirms. Pruitt picks up his hat. PRUITT_CONFRONTS_CALHOUN set — he goes to talk to Calhoun himself. Wroughtwood's power structure shifts.

SCENE NOTES

- **Calhoun's *"This isn't personal"*** is the most damning thing he says. He genuinely believes it. He has organized his entire moral framework around the idea that what he does to infected people is sanitation rather than murder. That's more frightening than hatred.
- **Marie making Ricky turn the gun on his uncle** is the only moment in the game where her power is fully visible. Every other use is subtle — implication, suggestion, things that could be explained away. This one cannot. Calhoun sees it. Marcus sees it. The game lets that sit without comment.
- **Marcus choosing to stop it** being a HUMANITY +15 moment is the point. The wolf would let it happen. The wolf has no reason to protect Aldous Calhoun. The choice to step in front of that gun is entirely human.
- **Jacob's arrival never being fully explained** is intentional. How did he know? How much of him is still in there? The game doesn't answer. The compass was pointing somewhere. Eleanor is in that house. Some things hold even in the wolf.
- **CALHOUN_OWES_MARCUS** is the most unexpected flag in the game and should feel that way. It doesn't make Calhoun good. It makes the world complicated in a true way.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
CHAINS_ACTIVE	Ambush successful, Night 9
CHAINS_PREVENTION_FAILED	Prevention path not taken or failed
CHAINS_PREVENTION_PARTIAL	Calhoun admitted Jacob, threshold raised
CALHOUN_ADMITTED_JACOB	Prevention scene, Choice B
CALHOUN_SHOT	Marie path, Marcus lets it play
CALHOUN_OWES_MARCUS	Marie path, Marcus stops it
CALHOUN_JACOB_VERDICT	Jacob path — ambiguous outcome
JACOB_HELPED_MARCUS	Jacob freed Marcus
PRUITT_CONFRONTS_CALHOUN	Aftermath, Pruitt told everything
CHAINS_RESOLVED	Any resolution — Marcus is free